EU: Malta's groundwater status worse in the third water plan

The Commission's 2026 plan comparison, tested against its 2019 text and EEA data

THE CLAIM

> ***"…no GWBs had a good chemical status in 2021, while a fifth of GWBs had a good chemical status in 2015."***

European Commission, SWD(2026) 702 final, Malta, 2 October 2026

Also: good quantitative status "decreased from 86.7% to 73.3% due to overabstraction".

GWB = groundwater body; Malta has 15.

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

Counts correct; cause not tested

SUPPORTED | **LARGELY SUPPORTED** | NOT SUBSTANTIATED | MISLEADING | CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

13 → 11

Quantity: two bodies fell

86.7% and 73.3% are 13 and 11 of 15 bodies. The 2019 Commission text and the EEA's database agree.

3 → 0

Chemistry: none left

A fifth is 3 of 15 in the second plan; all 15 bodies are in poor chemical status in 2021.

4 · 2 · 4

Back to the first plan

Poor quantitative status: four bodies in the first plan, two in the second, four in the third.

−10%

Abstraction did not rise

Eurostat's estimate of groundwater abstraction fell from 41.6 to 37.3 million m³ (2015–2021). Estimated.

Cause?

"Overabstraction": not tested

Monitoring grew from 3 to 7 bodies, and the document says comparability between cycles "might be low".

FAIR TO SAY

The Commission notes that quantitative monitoring rose from 3 to 7 bodies, that 8 of 15 are still not monitored, and that recharge has fallen with rainfall. It calls the monitored area's status "a systemic problem of overabstraction".

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

- ☐ Status of each of the 15 bodies in the second and third plans, with the method.
- ☐ Metered groundwater abstraction by body, 2013–2023.
- ☐ The basis of "due to overabstraction" in the Commission's text.
- ☐ Whether the larger monitoring network explains part of the change.